culture of the Soviet Union'.16 At the closing ceremony, Honecker mounted a floodlit marble stage to present dozens of youngsters with gilt-edged certificates of attendance, signed by himself.

Soon after, the FDJ manifesto was tweaked to state that a good understanding between the 'German youth and the most progressive youth movements in the world, especially the Russian youth, is one of the main objectives to be sought in order to regain equal rights for the German people.' Writing in Einheit, the SED's theoretical newspaper, Honecker had already described the Party's task to 'educate the young to become socialists and never to forget that they were the sons and daughters of the working people and the bearers of mankind's greatest idea'.17

In private, Honecker could not stomach statements from church groups on Christianity, and Herman Axman, also a SED member of the FDJ, poured out scorn on political rivals. Lighting a slow-burning fuse, Honecker set about limiting the influence of Christians at the FDJ's central training school and restricting them to delivering just two lectures (out of sixty on the programme).

Over the coming years, Christians and churches were singled out for persecution, culminating in the 'Jugendweihe' in 1955, an action undermining the church youth work and endangering the future of Christianity in East Germany. As the FDJ peeled off its democratic camouflage, leading CDU members and representatives of other political colours began quitting the movement.

No one was prepared for the brutal winter of 1946–47 when Germany slowly froze, succumbing to electricity cuts, burst pipes and coal shortages. As the situation worsened, Honecker deployed the FDJ to Saxony and Brandenburg to chop firewood and help shore up the fuel supply – placing the movement at the forefront of the public's consciousness. For a brief period, he hogged the limelight when helping hundreds of teenagers working at a coal mine. He also joined a group of boys dispatched to clean up farmland for the spring sowing. 'Many leaders and groups of the FDJ helped to ease the extremely arduous situation of the people during the long and hard winter,' he proudly recounted. As the snow mounds melted, he sent truckloads of FDJ boys to spearhead relief efforts during floods in